



Modernist pattern The relatively simple cut of American designer Elizabeth Hawes's evening dress ensures that the focus is on the modernist pattern of the fabric. The large falling leaves accentuate the movement of the flaring skirt.



Fluid material The cut and material of this English dress would have necessitated the right kind of underwear. The gown bears no label but the simple embroidery design suggests that it might have been made by a local dressmaker.



Revealing cut The cut of this dress by French designer Coco Chanel would have highlighted the wearer's fashionably bronzed back and arms. Gathered and draped in front and hugging the waist, the gown's skirt flares out below the hip.

1934



1939

Cap-sleeved overdress The overdress of Madeleine Vionnet's design is made of very fine black lace decorated with black bows. The shimmering silver lamé underdress, with a halterneck and very low back, could be worn on its own.



Butterfly embroidery This fine silk dress by French designer Mainbocher is embroidered with butterflies in iridescent spangles, which grow larger towards the hem. The dress would have been worn over a flesh-coloured slip.

JEAN HARLOW



When Howard Hughes's film *Hell's Angels* was released in 1930, 19-year-old Jean Harlow became an international star. Harlow popularized the white evening gown, and by bleaching her hair weekly completed the look and had an indirect influence on the sale of peroxide. American designer Adrian (Gilbert Adrian) created gowns for Harlow's role in *Reckless* (1935, above), accentuating her body with clinging, bias-cut dresses made of light-reflecting materials.